

Total Valve Systems

In-person interview · Internal IT / Systems (boots-on-the-ground, MSP co-managed) · Broken Arrow, OK



Your one move that wins the room: **you've already done this exact job, in this town.** You integrated the Exterranean cryogenic plant right here in Broken Arrow — trusted by the CEO — and Total Valve is another Broken Arrow manufacturer under new ownership. Lead with that.

SPEC 01

The Company — know this cold

Total Valve Systems has been a Broken Arrow fixture since 1983, running a 70,000 sq ft facility on a 10-acre site. They manufacture and service pressure relief valves, control valves, and custom/isolation valves for safety-critical, regulated customers. Walk in knowing this like you already work there.

Founded / footprint	1983 · 70,000 sq ft on ~10 acres · HQ 1300 E Memphis St, Broken Arrow, OK 74012
What they make	Pressure relief valves (PRVs), control, isolation & excess-flow valves — manufactured and serviced
Who they serve	Power, oil & gas, chemical, cryogenic, pulp/paper, food & beverage, pharma
Quality regime	ISO 9001:2015 · VR, UV, NB (National Board) & ASME certifications — records & traceability are sacred

Proprietary systems	Total Valve Live (real-time data), a proprietary valve testing database , web-based inventory/service tracking, the LiftTrack PSV device — their crown jewels
Footprint	~7 US sites + international (Shanghai, Jordan, India, Singapore)
Ownership / method	Recent new ownership ; uses Lean techniques · owner/president Mike Lybarger

REPUTATION REALITY CHECK — STEER WITH THIS, DON'T REPEAT IT

Indeed sits near **2.8/5**: good *people*, weaker *management*, "mediocre pay scale," and older mentions of limited training/raises. The shop's been called "behind the current times." Three consequences you'll use: **(1)** don't anchor salary first; **(2)** your questions about roadmap and budget are diligence, not rudeness; **(3)** "behind the times" + undocumented proprietary systems = your opening to be the person who brings order.

Decoding the role — "boots on the ground, works with the MSP"

This is **co-managed IT**: an MSP handles some backend/tooling; you're the physical presence, the triage brain, and the business-context owner. Prove you know exactly where that line sits.

THE MSP FRAMING — SAY THIS ALMOST VERBATIM

"In a co-managed setup I'm the single throat to choke internally — I own the outcome and the user relationship, while the MSP is responsible for executing on the infrastructure they're contracted for. My job is to triage what's truly ours versus theirs, hold them to SLA, and make sure nothing falls in the cracks between us." No technician they've talked to will say this.

SPEC 02

Your Spine — the thread through every answer

Across three of your four anchor jobs you did the **same thing Total Valve needs right now: integrated an acquired company, end to end, with your own hands.** Enerflex←Exterran,

ONEOK←Magellan, and AEP (standardized 12 admins down to 2). Total Valve just changed ownership — so you are, almost literally, a repeat customer for their exact problem.

★ YOUR SINGLE BIGGEST HOOK — OPEN WITH THIS

The Exterran flagship you integrated was the **cryogenic-compression manufacturing plant right here in Broken Arrow** — the strategic crown jewel of the whole Enerflex deal (Enerflex's own history credits the Broken Arrow plant as what "unlocked new opportunities"). You were the **on-site go-to for the executives, including the CEO**. One sentence tells them: *I've already done exactly this job, in this town, in a manufacturing plant, trusted by the top of the house.*

SAY IT

"Integrating acquired companies and standardizing messy environments is literally what I've done for years — and my flagship was the Exterran plant right here in Broken Arrow. That's the exact phase Total Valve is in, and I do it hands-on, not from a slide deck."

OVERQUALIFICATION DEFENSE — KEEP IT LOADED

You're not a PM who'll be bored doing desktop support — **you're the PM and the technician**. You imaged the machines, you were the AutoCAD SME, you did the post-install. That duality is exactly what an owner-led shop needs in one person. Say it out loud if you sense the "is he too senior?" hesitation: *"I'm not after a title — I want to plant roots in Broken Arrow and own an environment end to end. Knowing where every wire goes is the part I actually enjoy."*

Bonus edge: AEP (utility), ONEOK (midstream), Enerflex (energy/compression) are exactly the kinds of power and oil & gas companies that *buy* Total Valve's valves. You understand their customers' world from the inside.

SPEC 03

The Four Stories

Rehearse each **out loud** until the arc is automatic — Situation → Task → Action → Result, 60–90 seconds. Lead with the hook; deploy detail cards only when they probe.

① The Broken Arrow Integration (Enerflex ← Exterran) — FLAGSHIP

Proves: you integrated a Broken Arrow manufacturing plant end to end through an acquisition — trusted by the CEO, hands-on from the trench to the ERP.

The facts, said confidently: Enerflex *acquired* Exterran (completed Oct 2022, ~\$735M, all-stock — direction matters, say it that way). The Broken Arrow cryogenic plant was the crown jewel and your focus. You were the on-site go-to for the execs and CEO.

SAY IT

"My flagship is honestly why Total Valve jumped out at me — because I've basically already done this job, in this town. When Enerflex acquired Exterran, the crown jewel of that deal was the Exterran manufacturing plant right here in Broken Arrow — the cryogenic facility. That plant was my focus, and I was the on-site go-to for the executives, including the CEO when he was in town. Exterran had deferred IT investment for years waiting on the buyout, so I modernized the whole thing end to end: a full hardware refresh and server-room rebuild, a company-wide network redesign, migrating the ERP from Oracle to SAP, moving everyone to Office 365, replacing the old Avaya phones with Microsoft Teams, rebuilding the conference rooms, and running workshops to get people onto cloud apps. And I did it hands-on — I was also the AutoCAD SME for the engineers. Production never stopped. So a Broken Arrow manufacturer under new ownership? That's the exact situation I just spent years succeeding in."

Delivery note: don't recite the whole portfolio — lead with the hook + 3–4 highlights, then let the cards answer follow-ups.

Detail cards — deploy the one they probe

① HARDWARE + SERVER ROOM

Exterran waited for the acquisition so Enerflex would open the wallet — everything was 2–3 years past lifecycle. I replaced the whole fleet: engineering laptops, business laptops, monitors, switches, printers — and we practically rebuilt the server room. Ground-up modernization, not a patch.

② ★ NETWORK REDESIGN — THE WELDER STORY (your signature card)

The buildings were on a fragile topology — if one building's Cisco 3560 switch went down, **every** building went down. And it actually happened four separate times... because a welder kept unplugging the switch to run a second microwave. That's a manufacturing floor — production and IT physically collide. I worked with the stakeholders and network admins to design and implement a company-wide upgrade that killed those single points of failure, so one unplugged switch could never take down the business again.

Why it's your best card: memorable, a little funny, and it proves you design infrastructure that survives welders, power draws, and human reality. A valve-and-welding shop will *feel* this one.

③ ERP — ORACLE → SAP

I migrated the backbone ERP from Oracle to SAP — the system the whole manufacturing business runs on. Staged, validated, business coordinated the whole way so we didn't lose data or stop operations.

④ RECORDS → SHAREPOINT / 0365

They had a pile of third-party document-retention apps. I consolidated them into 0365/SharePoint — one governed place for records. *Tie-in: that's the records discipline an ISO 9001 shop like yours lives on.*

⑤ TELEPHONY — AVAYA → MS TEAMS

I migrated the old Avaya phone system to Microsoft Teams and ported all the existing numbers — but sequenced it *after* the network upgrade, because voice-over-Teams is only as good as the network under it. Order of operations mattered.

⑥ CONFERENCE ROOMS — NEAT BAR + M365

Upgraded all the conference rooms with Neat Bar systems integrated with Microsoft 365, so meetings actually worked and matched the new cloud stack.

⑦ CHANGE MANAGEMENT — CLOUD WORKSHOP

I didn't just deploy the cloud apps — I ran a workshop to transition users onto them. In a plant, adoption is the hard part, not installation. *Tie-in: I'll win over your floor, not impose on it.*

⑧ AUTOCAD SME + FIBER BUILD

Throughout, I was the AutoCAD SME for engineering, and I project-managed the directional boring of new underground fiber between buildings — equally at home supporting a CAD workstation and standing over a trench.

② Overlaying the Network (ONEOK ← Magellan, \$18.8B)

Proves: you integrate acquisitions at massive multi-site scale — bringing acquired locations onto the parent's standards.

SAY IT

"At ONEOK I worked on one of the biggest integrations you can be part of — they acquired Magellan Midstream, around an eighteen-point-eight-billion-dollar deal, and suddenly all of Magellan's pipeline locations had to come onto ONEOK's environment. I project-managed the overlay of ONEOK's network onto those Magellan sites and owned the conversion and ongoing support. It was heavily multi-site — bringing acquired locations up to the parent's standard while keeping those users productive. I also worked with Citrix and Starlink to keep remote, hard-to-reach locations connected. Total Valve isn't just the Broken Arrow plant — you've got sites across a lot of states and offices overseas. Standardizing distributed locations is something I've done at real scale."

Get the figure right: \$18.8 billion (announced May 2023, closed that September) — not \$1.8B. Precision here protects your credibility.

③ Twelve Admins Down to Two (AEP)

Proves: you make IT dramatically leaner — more done with fewer people — the whole value proposition for a cost-conscious shop under new ownership running Lean.

SAY IT

"At AEP I ran a project to build out 300 workstations — standardized, consistent, supportable at scale. But the bigger win was efficiency: the environment had twelve administrators and the ticket queue was always behind. I standardized the builds, applied JIT and Lean principles to how we provisioned, and drove the backlog down. By the end the same environment ran on two administrators instead of twelve. Not by cutting corners — by standardizing so the work simply didn't need that much overhead. I know a shop under newer ownership cares about running lean, and you already use Lean techniques here — so we'd be speaking the same language."

FRAMING CAUTION

Frame 12→2 as **standardization and automation**, never "I cut people." If asked: the others were freed up / redeployed to higher-value work because the environment no longer needed that much manual administration.

④ The Rescue (Alorica — saved a failing Win7 → Win10 rollout)

Proves: you perform under real pressure, carry an entire site single-handedly, and protect the customer relationship when it's on the line. This is your best answer to "can you handle being the only IT person?"

SAY IT

"At Alorica I got put on a situation already going sideways. One of our large call centers had fallen behind on the Windows 7 to Windows 10 migration, and the client was frustrated enough that they were threatening to pull their business — so the account itself was on the line, not just a deadline. I took it on and upgraded the entire center single-handedly, then stayed on for post-install support across all the different client programs on that floor, each with its own apps and quirks, so the agents kept working and kept hitting their numbers. We got it back on track and the client stayed. Two takeaways: I hold up under pressure when there's real money on the line, and I can carry an entire site by myself — which is basically what being your internal IT person is."

IF THEY ASK FOR A MISTAKE YOU PERSONALLY MADE

This is a *rescue* story, not a personal-error story — don't force it. Two clean options: **(A)** a small honest snag from a real rollout (a driver/app that broke on an image) → own it → workaround → root cause → the check you added so it couldn't recur (end on the **corrective-action** framing — ISO language). **(B)** the honest pivot: "Early on I tried to do too much myself before documenting — I learned to write the runbook as I go so I'm never the single point of failure."

WHICH STORY FOR WHICH QUESTION

- "Tell me about yourself" / biggest project / ownership change → ① (open with the Broken Arrow hook)
- Multi-site / remote locations → ②
- Efficiency / lean / small team / budget / project management → ③
- Under pressure / a challenge / can you carry it solo → ④
- ERP → ①③card · CAD → ①⑧card · plant-floor networking → ①②card (welder) · records/ISO → ①④card · telephony → ①⑤card · change management → ①⑦card

SPEC 04

Dos & Don'ts

Do

- **Lead with ownership language:** "I'd own that," "I'd make sure that doesn't fall through the cracks."
- **Translate tech into business:** downtime = missed valve shipments = an angry power-plant customer. Show you get the stakes.
- **Respect the floor.** Say you'll walk it, learn the systems, and fix things where people work — not from behind a ticket queue.
- **Ask about the proprietary systems** (Total Valve Live, the testing DB). Curiosity there signals you know what's actually critical.
- **Bring 3–4 printed résumés** and a notepad. It's a shop; paper still lands.
- **Dress one notch above the floor:** collared shirt/polo, pressed slacks, clean closed-toe shoes. You may get a floor walk.
- **Close the loop:** ask about next steps and timeline before you leave; get names for thank-yous.

Don't

- **Don't trash their legacy stack.** "Behind the times" is your *opportunity*, never your *criticism*. Frame: stabilize → document → improve incrementally.
 - **Don't over-promise IaC/automation on day one** (see Tech Refresher — match the tool to the shop).
 - **Don't volunteer a salary number first.** Let them anchor.
 - **Don't drown non-technical interviewers in acronyms.** Owner-led shop — read the room and translate.
 - **Don't be the remote/cloud evangelist.** This is a be-in-the-building, hands-on role — show you *want* that.
 - **Don't bad-mouth past employers or recruiters.** Ever.
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SPEC 05

Technical Quick-Training

You know this — this is to load it in RAM so it's instant. Each area: the concept + the one-liner that shows seniority.

Active Directory / Identity (Entra ID)

On-prem AD DS (domains, OUs, GPOs, security groups, DNS/DHCP); hybrid identity via Entra Connect; lifecycle onboarding and — critically — **clean same-day offboarding**.

Seniority line: "Least-privilege by default, group-based access so permissions are auditable, and offboarding that actually revokes access same-day — non-negotiable in an ISO shop."

Microsoft 365 / Exchange / Azure

M365 admin, Exchange Online, SharePoint/OneDrive/Teams, Intune + Conditional Access (MFA, block legacy auth), and license hygiene as cost control. Your Boeing Exchange + O365 migration history is gold.

Seniority line: "I treat license management as cost control, not just provisioning — reclaiming seats on offboard adds up fast."

Endpoint & imaging

Standard image / Autopilot + Intune (or MDT/WDS on-prem), patch & driver management for older shop-floor/test-bench PCs, and a spares strategy so a dead floor PC is a 20-minute swap, not a lost day. Your Alorica Win7→10 migration is the proof point.

Networking (the plant-floor angle)

VLANs (office / shop-floor / guest / OT), switching, Wi-Fi across a metal-heavy 70k sq ft floor, VPN/SD-WAN to remote sites, firewall/DNS/DHCP.

Seniority line: "On a manufacturing floor I'd segment shop-floor and office traffic — partly for performance, mostly so a compromised office PC can't reach a test bench or a machine controller." *(And you have the welder story to prove you live this.)*

Backup / DR / Continuity

3-2-1 with an immutable/air-gapped copy as ransomware insurance; RTO/RPO thinking (an ISO shop's audit records can't be lost); and **tested restores**.

Seniority line: "A backup you haven't restored is a hope, not a plan." Often the most impressive area in an SMB interview.

Security (manufacturing = prime ransomware target)

MFA everywhere, EDR, patching, least privilege, email filtering, awareness, segmented backups. Tie recommendations to cyber-insurance requirements if budget resistance comes up ("this isn't gold-plating, it's what our insurance will require"). Calm and prioritized — never fear-mongering.

OT / IT convergence (your manufacturing differentiator)

Test benches, data-acquisition rigs (their Total Valve Live), machine controllers, label/barcode printers, handheld scanners — often old Windows that can't be freely patched.

Seniority line: "Floor equipment often can't be patched on a normal cycle — so I isolate it, control what talks to it, and monitor it, rather than pretending it's a laptop."

Infrastructure as Code — play it as direction, not day-one demand

Don't walk in promising Terraform pipelines — for a co-managed SMB role that reads as a flight risk. Fluency signals you're ahead of "the machine shop behind the times," so frame it as **stabilize & document first, automate second**. Where it realistically fits here: **PowerShell** for onboarding/offboarding & reporting, **Intune/Autopilot config profiles** (config-as-code), documented Conditional Access, Bicep/ARM *only if* there's real Azure, and a Git-tracked runbook. Your real edge is the PowerShell/automation/n8n work you already do — lead with that, not enterprise buzzwords.

ITSM & documentation — your quiet superpower

A shop with undocumented proprietary systems is one bus-factor away from disaster. Offer to build the runbook, asset inventory, and network diagram nobody's written. For an ISO shop, "we document what we change" mirrors their quality culture perfectly.

Likely Questions & Strong Answers

"Walk me through your experience."

~90 seconds, anchored on the Broken Arrow integration; end on "so a co-managed, boots-on-the-ground role in a Broken Arrow manufacturing shop is squarely what I've done best."

"Why do you want to work here?"

Roots in Broken Arrow, want to own an environment end to end, and Total Valve is at exactly the phase — new ownership, proprietary systems needing a steward — where you add the most value. Never "I need a job."

"A user's PC is down and they've got a valve shipment due — go."

Triage impact (one user or the line?), get them working fast even via a temporary swap, then root-cause. You optimize for business continuity, not a clean ticket close.

"How do you work with an MSP?"

The single-throat-to-choke framing from Spec 02 — hold SLA, prevent gap-tickets, align their work to floor reality.

"We have older/custom systems. How do you approach that?"

Stabilize → document → improve incrementally. "The risk in undocumented proprietary systems is the bus factor — I'd make sure I can recover them before I change anything."

"Biggest weakness / a time something failed."

A real, contained one with recovery + a control added afterward. In an ISO shop, frame it as a corrective action — they respect owning a mistake and hardening the process.

"Where do you see yourself in 5 years?"

Still here, having documented and stabilized the stack, the person the floor and the owners both trust. Roots, not a launchpad.

SPEC 07

Questions You Ask Them — bring 4–5, ask 3–4

Engineered to look senior and quietly surface the pay/culture/roadmap risks.

1. "What does the split look like today between what the internal person handles and what the MSP owns — and what's been falling in the cracks?"
2. "The proprietary systems like Total Valve Live and the testing database — who supports those today, and how well documented are they?" (You already know their crown jewels — huge

signal.)

3. "With the new ownership, is there an IT roadmap or budget for modernization, or is the near-term priority stability?" (Probes the investment reputation diplomatically.)
4. "What would a successful first 90 days look like to you?"
5. "How does the team like to work with IT — comfortable with tickets, or a walk-the-floor, tap-on-the-shoulder culture?"
6. If rapport is good: "What's kept the people who've stayed here a long time?"

Save salary for when **they** raise it.

SPEC 08

Salary Strategy

GIVEN THEIR "MEDIocre PAY" REPUTATION

- **Your band:** ~\$78K–\$88K for Systems Admin II/III-level work. This role may come in lower given the shop's reputation — go in knowing that.
- **Rule #1: let them anchor.** "I'd rather understand the full scope before we talk numbers — what range has the role budgeted?"
- **If forced to give one:** anchor to scope, give a range, leave room — "for the internal-owner role with the security and documentation pieces we discussed, I'd be looking in the low-to-mid 80s, but I care more about fit and the total package than an exact number."
- **Levers if base is tight:** PTO, schedule/flex, **cert reimbursement** (turns their "no training" weakness into your benefit), a 90-day review-and-raise, title, mileage/vehicle if multi-site travel is involved.
- **Don't accept or reject in the room.** "Let me think it over" is always fine. Know your real floor before you go in.

SPEC 09

Day-Of Logistics

- **Address:** 1300 E Memphis St, Broken Arrow, OK 74012. Drive it the day before; find the office entrance vs. shipping/receiving.
- **Arrive 10–15 min early** — not more, not less.

- **Bring:** 3–4 printed résumés, pen, notepad with your questions, a folder, ID (plants log visitors), references ready.
 - **Phone on silent, in pocket** — not on the table.
 - **Attire:** business-casual-plus. If they offer a floor walk-through, you'll be glad you skipped the full suit.
 - **First impression:** firm handshake, eye contact, learn and use names, be warm with reception.
 - **On a floor tour:** show genuine interest, ask what the systems are, don't touch anything, note where IT pain visibly lives (that PC duct-taped to a test bench is a talking point).
 - **Close:** "I'm very interested — what are the next steps and your timeline?"
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SPEC 10

The Game Plan

Two days before

- ☐ Re-read this manual; make sure every résumé bullet has a 30-second story behind it.
- ☐ Rehearse the four stories **out loud** — especially the Broken Arrow hook and the welder card.
- ☐ Look up your interviewers on LinkedIn if you have names.
- ☐ Confirm time, format, and who you're meeting.

Day before

- ☐ Print résumés; pack the folder; lay out clothes.
- ☐ Drive the route / confirm entrance & parking.
- ☐ Reread Spec 02 (hook + MSP framing), Spec 05 one-liners, Spec 07 questions, Spec 08 salary.
- ☐ Sleep. Sharp beats over-prepared-and-fried.

Morning of

- ☐ Eat. Water. Get there early.
- ☐ Re-read your 6 questions and the hook in the parking lot.
- ☐ Walk in as the person who's already done this job — because you have.

Within 24 hours after

- ☐ Send a short, specific thank-you to each interviewer — reference something you actually discussed (the proprietary systems, the floor tour).

★ THE MINDSET

You've done every hard part of this job already — the acquisition integration, the solo rescue, the enterprise rigor, the plant-floor reality. Total Valve needs exactly that and probably hasn't had it. Walk in calm. You're not hoping they pick you; you're evaluating whether the fit and the number work for *you*. That quiet, grounded competence is what closes manufacturing interviews. Go get it.